Week one in your Instantly account: what I check

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UnpauseAI

The audit is read-only: nothing in your account changes during it. At the end of the week you get a short report ranked by impact, with the first two or three changes I'd make. Where a check caught something in the campaigns I ran this year, the number is in bold.

1 Deliverability

Every sending account: warmup on, a daily limit set, account healthy, SPF, DKIM and DMARC published on its domain	One weak sender drags down the reputation of the domain it shares with the others.
Bounce rate per campaign, split by the recipient's mail server	A July batch where every address was NeverBounce "valid" bounced at **8.6%**; **10 of the 11** bounces sat behind Mimecast, a security gateway a verifier can't see. With those domains held out, the next two waves bounced at **1.5%** and **0%**.

2 Sequence and sending settings

The delay on each step	A step's delay is the wait before the *next* email. A gap entered on the step it precedes sends the follow-up about 20 minutes after the first email.
Gap between emails and daily limits, against list size	An 11-minute gap inherited from an older campaign held sends at **45 a day** against 75 expected. Cutting it to 5 minutes brought it to about **72**.
Campaigns that already hold a finished run	A step added to a completed campaign set it active again and put **533 of its 556** finished leads back in the sequence. A new run goes in a fresh campaign.
Stop on reply, sending window, recipients' time zone	The window follows the recipients' time zone, not the sender's. North American and European clocks change on different weekends, so cross-Atlantic schedules get rechecked in March and October.

3 Lists

Verification and mail-server type before every load	Domains behind Mimecast, or with no mail server at all, are held out before they can bounce.
The same person in two campaigns	New leads are deduplicated against the whole workspace, not only the campaign they are going into: the last wave was checked against all **10,544** leads in the account.
Customers, open deals and opt-outs, checked against your own records	A re-check just before one launch found **28 new bookings in nine days**, one of them in the send list. The stop-list is refreshed every week.
Merge fields	Any lead whose first name, company or custom field is empty gets fixed or pulled before it renders as a blank in the email.

4 Replies and reporting

Human replies, counted apart from automatic ones	Across two cold waves, out-of-office and leave notices outnumbered human replies **27 to 10**.
Replies flagged interested, against who actually answered them	In one audit, **seven** interested replies had no confirmed answer from anyone; one asked to reserve 10 seats.
Lead counts by status	Instantly's active status also covers leads that were never emailed: **258 of 267** counted as in sequence had not had a first email. Progress is read from the last-contact date.
Open rates	Apple Mail's privacy protection loads tracking pixels on its own, so opens are read as a trend, never as interest.

5 Every week after that

Campaign	Sent	Bounced	Human replies	Automatic replies	Interested, not yet answered	Meetings booked	Unsubscribed	Change this week
one row per live campaign	this week	count and %	people, not emails	out of office, leave	names, for your team	from your calendar or CRM	count	what changed and what it should move

Every figure is counted from the campaign data when the report is written, never typed in by hand.

One change at a time. One change per campaign per week, logged with its date and the number it should move, then read again a week later. That way each result traces back to the change that caused it.

Nothing changes without your yes. I propose a change, with what it touches and whether it can be undone. Anything that sends mail, loads leads or edits a live sequence waits for your approval.

Figures from campaigns I ran for a UK events company in 2026 (anonymized). Details in the attached case study.